

Task-to-workflow canvas

Map 1 repeated task, test the normal path and 6 failures, then decide what happens next.

Map the task before you connect a tool

Complete all 15 fields. Then run the processing rules, quality bar and stop rules before the workflow handles real work.
Run the task by hand once. Keep the map narrow. If a stop rule is true, do not automate the task until the problem is fixed or the task moves to the correct system.

1. TASK AND CURRENT OWNER

Name the repeated task, its current owner and why it repeats.

2. USEFUL RESULT

What must be true when the task is finished?

3. TRIGGER AND START-ONCE RULE

Name the exact start event and how the same start is blocked from running twice.

4. FREQUENCY, VOLUME AND SCOPE

Record how often, how many items and what must stay outside this workflow.

5. REQUIRED INPUTS

List every file, field, message or event needed before the 1st step.

6. SOURCE OF TRUTH

Where does each important fact come from? What source wins when sources disagree?

7. FIXED STEPS IN ORDER

Write every step from trigger to finish. If the next step cannot be known now, test whether this needs an agent.

8. OWNER FOR EVERY STEP

Mark each step Human, Automation or AI. Name 1 person who owns the whole workflow.

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WORKED EXAMPLE: AI JARGON GUIDE DELIVERY

Task: deliver the requested guide. Trigger: 1 popup request for guide.ai-jargon-guide. Duplicate rule: 1 delivery run per request ID. Required tag: guide_ai_10_words_pdf. Output: immediate and email delivery of 10-ai-words-you-need-to-know.pdf. Finish check: delivery succeeds. Failure: rejected send or bounce stops later messages, logs the error, alerts Fatiha and creates a manual resend item with the reader, guide and error.

9. ACCESS AND PERMISSIONS

Name the smallest mailbox, folder, record, field or action each step may use.

10. OUTPUT AND FINISH CHECK

Record the output format, destination and visible proof that the task finished correctly.

11. RULES AND HUMAN APPROVAL

What must stay true, what must never happen and which actions need approval from which named person?

12. EXCEPTIONS AND HANDOFF

List unusual cases, the owner for each and the response time.

13. FAILURE HANDLING

Record the error log, owner alert, retry limit, duplicate protection and manual fallback.

14. TEST SET

Record evidence from the normal run and all 6 failure cases. Complete the checks on page 3.

15. RUN RECORD AND DECISION

Record what started, finished, failed or needed human help, and name who decides.

DECISION

 **KEEP**  **CHANGE**  **STOP**

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Break it on purpose before you increase volume

Check a box only when the test or control has passed and the evidence is recorded on page 2.

7 TEST CASES

- ☐ Normal run
- ☐ Missing input
- ☐ Wrong input
- ☐ Duplicate trigger
- ☐ Provider failure
- ☐ Bad output
- ☐ Human-review case

9 PROCESSING RULES

- ☐ Complete the task manually once before automating it.
- ☐ Accept only the named trigger and block duplicate starts before step 1.
- ☐ Check every required input and source before processing.
- ☐ Follow the fixed steps in order. Do not guess a new path.
- ☐ Give each step 1 owner and only the access it needs.
- ☐ Pause before every action that needs human approval.
- ☐ When a step fails, stop the action, write the error, alert the owner and stay inside the retry limit.
- ☐ Use the manual fallback when the workflow cannot finish safely.
- ☐ Save the run record and make a Keep, Change or Stop decision before increasing volume.

10-POINT QUALITY BAR

- ☐ The task passed 1 manual run before automation.
- ☐ The trigger creates 1 run and duplicate starts create no repeated action.
- ☐ Every required input and source of truth is named and allowed.
- ☐ Every fixed step has an owner and can be followed in order.
- ☐ Each step has only the access it needs.
- ☐ The output, destination and visible finish check are clear.
- ☐ Human approvals, exceptions and response times have named owners.
- ☐ The normal path and all 6 failure cases have passed.
- ☐ Every failure creates a log, alert, safe stop and manual fallback.
- ☐ The run record ends with a named Keep, Change or Stop decision.

10 STOP RULES: ANY CHECKED RULE MEANS DO NOT AUTOMATE

- ☐ There is no clear trigger or finished result.
- ☐ You cannot complete the task manually once.
- ☐ Inputs are missing, unclear or not allowed.
- ☐ Access is broader than the task needs.
- ☐ An action involving a customer, money, private data, publishing, deletion or a lasting record lacks named approval.
- ☐ A duplicate trigger or retry could repeat the action.
- ☐ A failure can remain hidden or has no owner.
- ☐ There is no manual fallback.
- ☐ The next step cannot be written before the run. Evaluate an agent instead.
- ☐ Several always-on workflows need shared monitoring. Move the work to business operations.